

NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC

World

JULY 1986

Youth Circus

Birds of Prey

Sharks

Statue of Liberty

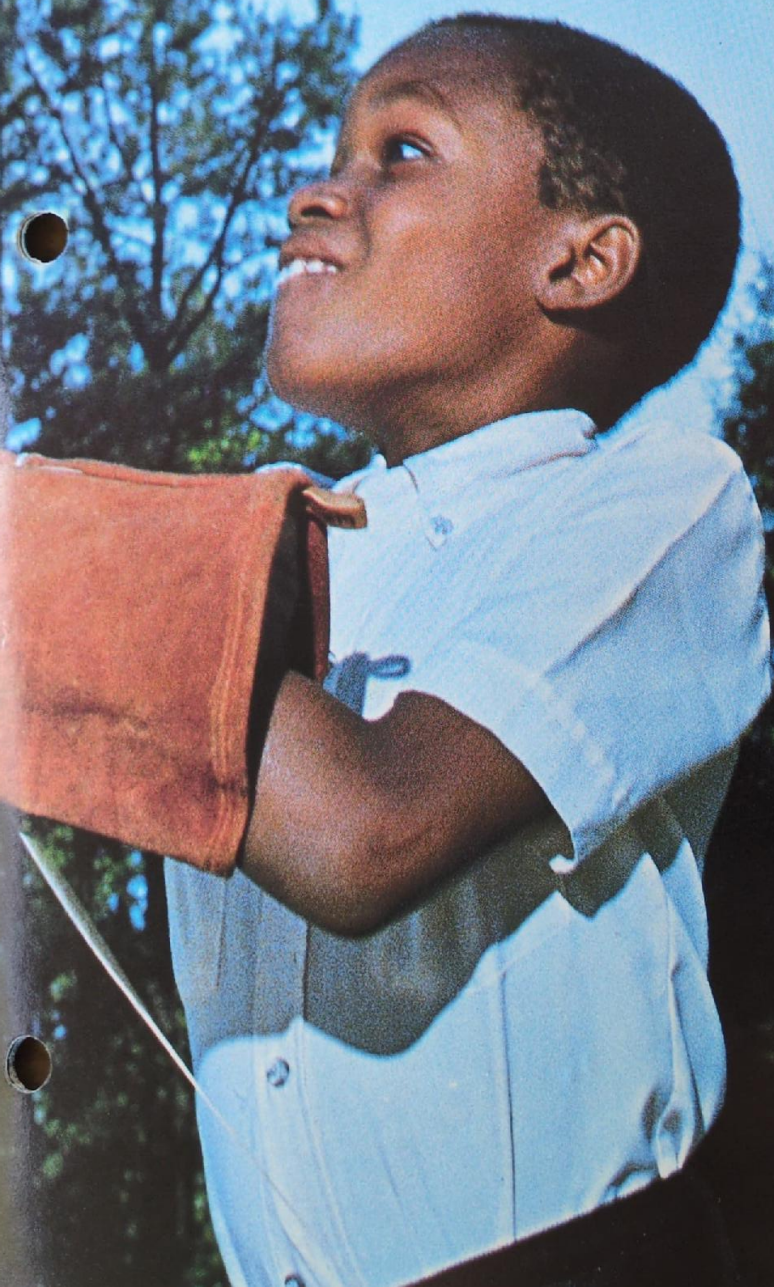


RAPTO



R HELPERS

Attached to a long leash, a screech owl flies from the hand of Bokah Worjolah, 9, of Charlotte, North Carolina. Gloves protect Bokah's arm from the bird's sharp talons, or claws. The owl has injured its wing. Now it exercises, and soon it will be strong enough to be set free. Bokah's class saw the owl at the Carolina Raptor Center, in Charlotte. The center cares for injured and orphaned raptors—birds of prey. To learn more about the center, turn the page.





A BALD EAGLE named King George (above) will remain at the center. Wounded by a bullet, he cannot fly.

FAST FRIENDS. Sigmund, a red-tailed hawk, perches on Eileen Chen's glove (below). The center's director, Dr. Richard Brown, lends a hand. "At first, I was nervous because Sigmund looked so fierce," says Eileen, 10. "Soon I got to like him."

"I really enjoyed seeing the birds, especially the owls," says Eileen Chen. Eileen, 10, is among Bokah Worjolah's fourth grade classmates at Charlotte Country Day School. The class visited the Carolina Raptor Center last year.

The Carolina Raptor Center is one of seven regional centers in the United States. It shelters about 150 injured or orphaned raptors—birds of prey. Raptors hunt small animals such as mice and rats.

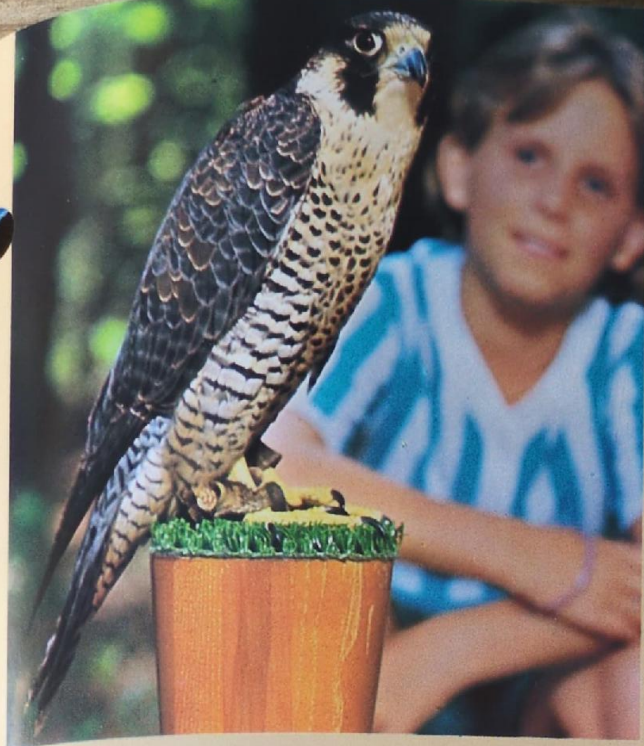
"Many of our birds have been shot," says Dr. Richard Brown, who directs the center. "Some have been hit by vehicles, and others caught in traps or in chimneys. We also take orphaned chicks that people find." Usually, veterinarians care for the birds until they can be returned to the wild.

Some "patients," however, are too badly injured to be released. They stay at the center and are used for breeding and for public-education programs. "Most species of raptors are either endangered or threatened," says Dr. Brown. "People still shoot birds of prey because they think they kill chickens and other domestic fowl."

Actually, raptors seldom attack farm animals, and they also help the environment. "They keep down the numbers of mice, rats, and other small animals that destroy crops," says Dr. Brown. "In this way, they help maintain a natural balance, so there is food for all."

If you would like to learn more about raptors and how to help them, write to Carolina Raptor Center, Box 16443, Charlotte, NC 28297.





SITTING PRETTY. Sharp eyes gleaming, a peregrine falcon rests atop a perch at the raptor center (left). Lynn Hendrick, 10, admires the bird, named Helen. Helen was shot in a wing and can no longer fly. She receives tender, loving care at the center, as do about 150 other birds at any given time.



HELPING HANDS. Dr. Robert Gochnauer, a veterinarian who works as a volunteer at the center, prepares a barred owl named Memo for X ray (above). Memo has a broken leg, and Dr. Gochnauer wants to see how it is healing. The owl wears a bandage and a splint on its talon to help the leg heal. The X ray (right) shows a steel pin the doctor inserted to set the bone. Soon after the X ray was taken, the pin was removed, and Memo began to use his leg again. "I often get emergency calls to treat birds," says Dr. Gochnauer. "Many have been shot or caught in traps." He adds, "Raptors are an endangered part of our environment. Helping to save them is rewarding work."





"WHO GIVES A HOOT?" The people who brought these orphaned great horned owls to the center do. Now fully grown and healthy, the birds will soon be released into the wild.